



STRONG EL NINO, INDIAN OCEAN CONDITION ALSO NOT FAVOURABLE

Decade’s driest monsoon looms: Met cuts estimate to 90% of 50-yr average

Silver lining: Foodgrain stocks ample, reservoir levels adequate

Amitabh Sinha & Anjali Marar
New Delhi, Bengaluru, May 29

INDIA IS staring at the driest monsoon season in a decade, with the Met office Friday making a downward revision its earlier forecast and predicting only 90 per cent rain this season.

In April, in its first forecast for this year’s monsoon, India Meteorological Department (IMD) had said the country was likely to get 92 per cent of the long-

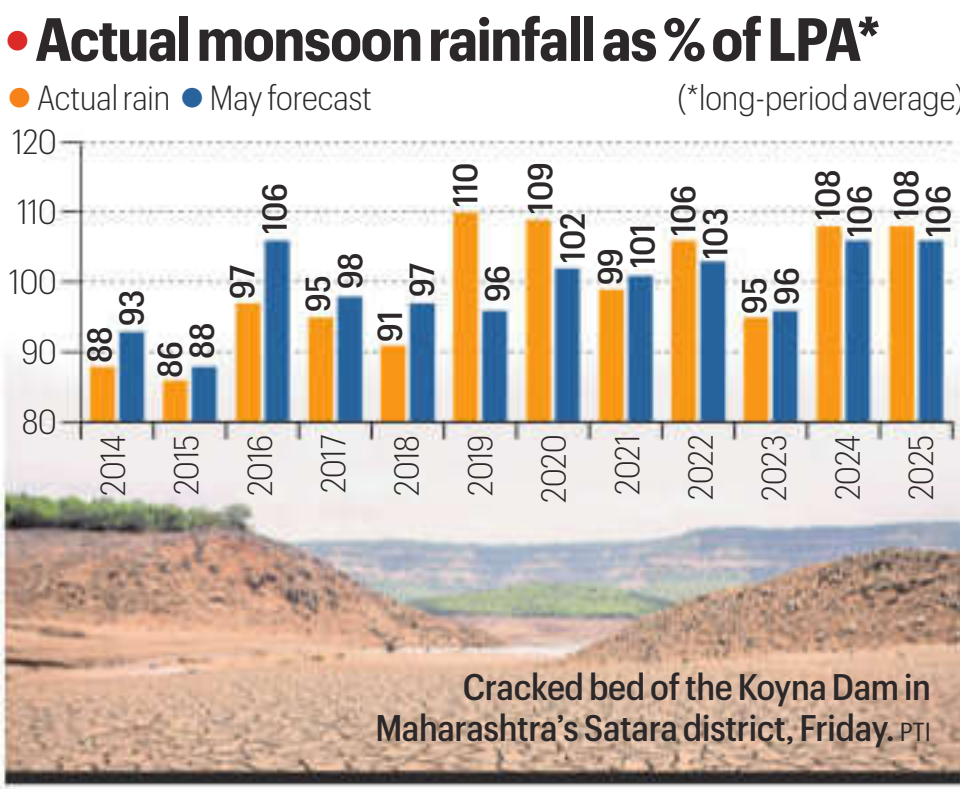
period average (LPA) rainfall during the four-month season.

The LPA, revised every 10 years, is the average rainfall over the 50-year period 1971-2020, which is considered the baseline, or normal. Its current value is 89 cm for the rainy season — June to September — across the country as a whole.

The latest forecast is the lowest by IMD in the last 20 years.

If this holds, India could be in for the driest rainy season

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



ADDRESSES CONCERNS OVER DELAY

Bail to verdict: SC pushes High Courts to speed up justice

Directs judgment be delivered within 3 months of matter being reserved, uploading of bail plea order the same day

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 29

E. EXPLAINED

Flags litigant’s right

ADDRESSING CONCERNS over undue delay in pronouncement of judgments reserved by judges, the Supreme Court issued directions Friday to all high courts to pronounce verdicts within three months of hearing the case and to “display extra promptitude” in cases of personal liberty and bail.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi said the directions were intended to strengthen the judicial administration and ensure timely delivery of judgments.

Among the key directions, the Supreme Court said that

The SC has held that delay in pronouncing verdicts after hearing them is not only against the provisions of law but an infringement of the right to personal liberty guaranteed by the Constitution. The SC guidelines give litigants a right to seek redress against delays.

bail applications should be heard and the order should preferably be pronounced and uploaded the same day. If it is re-

NATION **PAGE 10**
NEET LEAK: PROBLEM WON’T END UNTIL ACCOUNTABILITY IS FIXED, SC TELLS NTA

served, it should be pronounced the next day and uploaded on the website.

The Supreme Court also called for reasoned judgments pronounced in open courts to be uploaded on the High Court website within 24 hours.

The directions came on a petition filed by four convicts serving life sentences whose criminal appeals had been reserved by the Jharkhand High

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 30~05~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer

writing of other topics in the main exam.

Sharp rise in obesity, diabetes in five years since 2019, shows latest health survey

Proportion of obese women jumps 6.7 percentage points; 4.4 for men

● Men and women who were overweight or obese

CATEGORY	2023-24 (NFHS-6)	2019-21 (NFHS-5)
Women (15-49 yrs) overweight or obese	30.70%	24%
Men (15-49 yrs) overweight or obese	27.30%	22.90%

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, May 29

ADULT OBESITY in India is rising fast, with the proportion of men and women in the 15-49 age group who were overweight or obese up by 4.4 and 6.7 percentage points, respectively, in five years between 2019 and 2024, according to the National Family Health Survey-6 (NFHS-6), released by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare Friday.

The NFHS-6, conducted in 2023-24 by the Union Health Ministry with the International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS), Mumbai as the nodal agency, covered around 6.79 lakh households across 715 districts in all States and UTs, except Manipur. It provides

“vital evidence” on population, health, nutrition and family welfare indicators.

As per the survey, the percentage of women who were overweight or obese increased to 30.7 per cent in 2023-24 from 24 per cent in 2019-21. The obesity was higher in urban areas than rural areas. In urban areas, 42.8 per cent women were reported overweight or obese, while the figure was 25.5 per cent in rural areas.

The percentage of men who were overweight or obese also increased to 27.3 in 2023-24 from 22.9 in 2019-21. In rural areas, 23 per cent men were reported obese, while in urban areas the figure was 36.3 per cent.

Like the spike in adult obesity, the burden of high blood

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● AT 81 CASES, INCLUDING 38 NOT LODGED BY NIA, THE NIA COURT IN DELHI IS HEARING 8 TIMES THE NUMBER RECOMMENDED BY THE TOP COURT

5th judge since 2022, 43 NIA cases: SC order on speedy UAPA trials & a reality check

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, May 29

EARLIER THIS month, the Supreme Court directed the setting up of exclusive NIA courts to enable timebound disposal of UAPA trials. “If there are more than 15 trials pending within the jurisdiction of a particular High Court... two courts will be set up. Whereas, where trials exceed 25, three courts will be set up,” a Division Bench comprising

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi ordered.

This followed a Court order that judges presiding over NIA courts not be burdened with additional work.

If a court stands as a stark contrast to this, it is the one headed by Special NIA Judge Prashant Sharma at Patiala House Court in Delhi. The most sensitive NIA cases are heard in the Capital, which has just one other NIA court be-

sides Justice Sharma’s.

Appointed on November 20, 2025, Justice Sharma is the fifth judge to head the Patiala House NIA court since September 2022. Its four previous presiding judges spent an average of 11 months each in the post.

There are 43 NIA cases pending before the court being tried under the UAPA — ranging from terrorism and cross-border conspiracy to radicalisation — apart from others involving money laundering and other charges.

● NIA COURT PENDENCY

● Only 18 of 53 designated NIA courts have no pending cases.

● Only 3 of 53 designated NIA courts deal exclusively with NIA cases.

● Jharkhand (28), Delhi (19), J&K (16), West Bengal (13), Chhattisgarh, Kerala and TN (8 each), Assam and Gujarat (6 each) rank the highest in terms of cases

pending for at least 5 yrs, or more

● Chhattisgarh: Highest number of cases under trial at 73, with 4 NIA dedicated courts.

● J&K, with 71 cases, has only 1 court; as does Jharkhand with 52 cases

● Delhi, with 44 cases and 2 NIA courts; West Bengal, with 38 cases and 3 courts

Of these 43 cases, in seven, Judge Sharma is hearing arguments afresh, with the accused and the NIA having almost completed their arguments before the previous judges were transferred. One of these cases was registered in 2017.

In these seven cases, it is the second or third time that hearings are being held afresh, and involve 87 accused, with arguments on charges against 32 still pending.

At 81 cases, including 43 under the UAPA and 38 not

lodged by the NIA, the NIA court headed by Judge Sharma is hearing eight times the number recommended by the Supreme Court (10 per judge). Over 2017, 2018 and 2019, the average disposal time of a case in this NIA court was seven, four and three years, respectively (against the Supreme Court’s “expectation” of one month). Eight cases in all were disposed of in this period.

On an average, Justice Sharma has held 19 hearings in these NIA cases, with a total of

132 hearings across the 43 cases.

A defence counsel for some of the accused told *The Indian Express* on the condition of anonymity: “The frequent transfer of judges causes delay... The process is prolonged especially in complex cases with a large number of accused persons.” Since getting bail in terror cases is extremely difficult, a delay also means longer incarceration as an undertrial.

Special Public Prosecutor

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Kalai-II hydel project gets forest nod amid white-bellied heron habitat concerns

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, May 29

IN ONE of the key habitats of the critically endangered white-bellied heron, the Environment Ministry’s Forest Advisory Committee (FAC) has granted in-principle forest clearance to the 1,200 MW Kalai-II hydroelectric project proposed on the Lohit river, a tributary of the Brahmaputra.

The clearance paves the way to clear 869 hectares of forest for the project, including submergence of 638 hectares in Anjaw and Namsai forest divisions, Arunachal Pradesh. The THDC India Ltd’s Rs 14,176.26-crore run-of-the-river project is proposed in Anjaw district bordering China, and will involve construction of a 128.5-m concrete gravity dam and an underground powerhouse. Compensatory afforestation for the project will be done in Madhya Pradesh as Arunachal Pradesh is a “hilly and forested state with forest cover more than two-third of the geographical area.

During the project’s appraisal on May 8, the state government’s nodal office informed FAC that the heron species “is not spotted in the area proposed for diversion”. FAC, however, stated since the presence of bird species is reported in the landscape, the project’s wildlife management plan shall be vetted/ reviewed by the Wildlife Institute of India. This will be done to ensure “landscape-level ecological coherence and consistency with mitigation measures...”

Prior to the FAC meeting on May 8, Soblam Malo, a project-affected person from Anjaw’s Chengung village, had written to the panel on reservations regarding the project. He said the bird had been sighted by wildlife researchers and locals in its riverine habitat along the length of Lohit river from upstream (Walong) to downstream (Parashuram Kund), including in the directly affected area of the Kalai II project such as Chenguinty. FAC directed that the wildlife management plan should have a special emphasis on conservation of habitat of the white-bellied heron, and have to be submitted along with a compliance report of the conditions laid down in the principle clearance.

Even as FAC was informed that no heron was spotted in the area proposed for diversion, Arunachal Pradesh forest department had officially recorded it in April 2021. It was also recorded in Kamlang Tiger Reserve downstream of Kalai-II project area. Arunachal forest department had documented the sighting of the elusive bird in April 2021.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Verdict within 3 months: SC to HCs

Court in 2022 but the verdicts were pronounced three years later. While deciding their plea, the Supreme Court chose to address what it described as a wider institutional issue affecting courts across the country.

In May 2025, the Supreme Court had taken note of a report in The Indian Express that highlighted how the Jharkhand High Court pronounced verdicts in 75 criminal appeals in a week, following a rap from the top court.

The Court said that orders in cases seeking bail or suspension of sentence should be communicated to the jail authorities

as soon as it is pronounced, and that the undertrial or convict must be released, preferably the same day or at most the next day.

It also said that if a judgment in a criminal appeal or a death reference is reserved and the appellant is in custody, then a clarification can be sought by the parties within seven days of the date of reserving the judgment.

The bench also said that at the end of every month, an automated list of reserved judgments that remain pending must be generated and placed before the Chief Justice of the High Court, with a copy to the bench concerned.

If a judgment is not delivered in three months of reserving the order, the Registrar General must place the matter before the Chief Justice, who is then required to bring the delay to the notice of the bench concerned within two weeks, the top court said.

Crucially, where a judgment remains pending despite these steps, the SC said the case must be reassigned to another bench for a fresh hearing.

A similar string of directions, aimed at improving access to justice were issued in a 2001 case, Anil Rai v. State of Bihar, in

which the Supreme Court noted that delivering judgments long after arguments had concluded could affect public confidence in the judicial process.

The Court had directed the Chief Justices of HCs to monitor reserved judgments and ensure lists of pending reserved matters were periodically prepared. It also held if a judgment remained pending for more than 3 months, a party could move an application seeking an early pronouncement. However, if six months lapsed without a judgment, the litigant could approach the CJ seeking reassignment of the case to another bench. However, implementation varied across high courts, and delays continued to surface.

Monsoon

since 2015, when the overall seasonal rainfall happened to be 86 per cent of the LPA.

In the last two decades, there have been only two other occasions — 2009 and 2014, apart from 2015 — when seasonal monsoon rain have remained below 90 per cent of LPA. This year looks all set to join that group. IMD’s updated forecast Friday showed there was a 60 per cent chance that the seasonal rainfall would be below 90 per cent of LPA. The IMD did not say what prompted the downward revision in its forecast. However, more recent assessments of the emerging El Nino in the equatorial Pacific Ocean, and of the Indian Ocean Dipole could be the possible reasons.

Since its previous forecast in April, more information about the emerging El Nino has become clear. El Nino, a large scale ocean-atmospheric interaction in the equatorial Pacific Ocean that influences weather patterns worldwide, is known to suppress rainfall over the Indian region.

There are predictions that this year’s El Nino, which could persist well into the next year, could develop into one of the strongest ever. The possibility of emergence of an El Nino has been known for the last few months, but forecasts made for this phenomenon during March and April usually suffer from a greater degree of uncertainty, something that is referred to as spring barrier.

The information coming about El Nino now is considered more accurate and robust. Recent forecasts suggest the formation of a strong El Nino.

“With these limitations (spring barrier) and the understanding back then regarding the intensity of the emerging El Niño, we made calculations of the monsoon forecast to be around 92 per cent in April. However, we have downgraded the forecast keeping in view two things — emergence of moderate-strong El Niño earlier in the season than anticipated. In addition, the transition of the Indian Ocean Dipole from neutral to positive is expected only during the latter-half of the monsoon season. All put together, we arrive at 90 per cent of LPA this year,” said a senior IMD official.

The Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) refers to the temperature differential of surface waters between Bay of Bengal and the Arabian Sea side. If the latter is warmer, that is considered a “positive IOD” and heralds a better monsoon that may offset, to some extent, the adverse impact of a strong El Nino.

IMD said Friday the El Nino was expected to be weak in June, moderate in July and August and strong in September. This would mean that most of the monsoon season would pass off when the El Nino phase is weak or moderate. However, its actual impact on the rainfall cannot be quantified.

As for IOD, the IMD’s earlier assessment was it would transition from a neutral state to positive state during monsoon season, which could counter some of the effects of the El Nino. But on Friday, the IMD said IOD was likely to remain neutral through the entire monsoon season.

This year, therefore, looks all set to end an unusually good run of monsoon seasons for India.

Five of the last seven years, including the last two years, had produced more than 100 per cent rainfall. The other two years, 2021 and 2023, were also not bad, bringing in 99 and 95 per cent rains respectively.

While low rainfall is, no doubt, a reason for concern, it might not bring immediate pain. India’s food grain stocks are in a comfortable state, following a good harvest last year. The impact of El Nino is likely to be felt only in second half of the monsoon season, by which time the kharif sowing season should be over. The major reservoirs of the country have sufficient amounts of water right now because of ample rains last year. Lack of adequate rain is expected to push temperatures up. IMD said the country was likely to see less than 92% rain in June.

SC relief for RIL

requirements under the 2001 SEBI circular in respect of position limits”. The case has its origins in RIL’s March 29, 2007 decision to raise funds for the completion of various projects to the extent of Rs 87,000 crore by selling shares of its listed subsidiary, RPL. It was decided to sell 5 per cent of its RPL shareholding, which roughly equated to 22.5 crore shares. The decision to sell the shares was based on the premise that RPL’s shares were overvalued.

From November 6, 2007 to November 29, 2007, RIL sold 20.29 crore shares out of the proposed 22.5 crore shares in the cash segment of NSE and BSE, out of which 2.25 crore shares were sold in the last 10 minutes, between 3.21.40 pm and 3.30 pm on November 29.

RIL realised Rs 4,500 crore from the sale of the shares in the cash segment and Rs 513 crore from the futures segment through the 12 agents, totalling an aggregate amount of Rs 5,013 crore.

The SEBI later concluded that by employing 12 agents to take separate positions within their Open Interest limits on its behalf, by executing separate agreements with each of them, and cornering 93.63 per cent of the November Futures of RPL, RIL acted in a fraudulent manner while dealing in RPL scrip.

The market regulator said an analysis of the trading strategy/pattern adopted by RIL in the cash market during November 2007, and specifically on November 2, 2007 being the expiry day of the November Futures of RPL, revealed a manipulation of the last half an hour settlement price, which was a violation of the SEBI Act, 1992, read with the PFUTP Regulations.

On appeal, the SAT found no error in the SEBI order.

Sharp rise in obesity

sugar is also climbing among those aged 15 years and above, the survey shows. The proportion of men reporting high or very high (>140mg/dl) blood sugar levels or taking medicine to control it increased to 20.9 per cent in 2023-24 from 15.6 per cent in 2019-21. The figure was higher in urban areas — 23.9 per cent of men reported battling high or very high blood sugar levels or being under medication to control while it was 19.7 per cent in rural areas.

The proportion of women reporting high blood sugar levels was lower compared to men but it has increased sharply from 2019 to 2024. As per the survey, 17.8 per cent of women reported having high or very high blood sugar levels or taking medicine to control it, up from 13.5 per cent in 2019-21.

In 2023-24, 21.9 per cent of urban women and 16.2 per cent of rural women reported having high or very high blood sugar levels or taking medicine to control it. The rate of caesarean-section deliveries has also been rising — particularly in private healthcare facilities.

The proportion of births at a private health facility delivered by caesarean section rose to 54.1 per cent in 2023-24 from 47.4 per cent in 2019-21. For public health facilities, it increased to 16.9 per cent from 14.3 per cent.

43 NIA cases

Rahul Tyagi, who is representing the NIA in many of these cases, is on the same side as the defence counsel on this, adding that if the new NIA courts come up, “the distribution of cases in them should be done in a manner that partly heard cases are not impacted and continue to stay with the current judge (concerned)”.

Section 11 of the NIA Act, incidentally, empowers the Central government to enable a judge to continue trying the case even if he retires, to ensure continuity and speedy trial.

On March 24, the Supreme Court first asked 17 states, including Delhi, to try and ensure that trials in UAPA (or terror) cases were completed within one year. The Division Bench of CJI Kant and Justice Bagchi also said states may set up dedicated NIA courts if more than 10 cases were pending under the jurisdiction of its High Court.

“There may be a case where one matter may take more than one month to conclude. But we are expecting that, on an average, one NIA case is concluded in a month. For this, you need to have day-to-day hearings,” the apex court said. It also directed that NIA courts “should exclusively deal with UAPA or other related trials and that such Presiding Officers should not be entrusted with any other cases”.

The Bench passed these directions while hearing a suo motu case registered in January, to oversee the creation of special courts to tackle the pendency of trials under special laws such as the UAPA. At the time, it was hearing a challenge to a Delhi High Court order denying bail to Md Heydaitullah, an alleged ISIS member accused of radicalising youths through cyberspace.

Heydaitullah and his seven co-accused had started arguments before the previous judge, who got transferred and now the hearing has re-commenced before Judge Sharma.

The 10 cases where Justice Sharma is hearing arguments afresh, including seven under the NIA, include:

● A 2020 case of an alleged al-Qaeda module operating across West Bengal and Kerala.

● A 2021 case pertaining to alleged publication and dissemination of an “ISIS-linked” digital magazine.

● A 2021 case against gangster and designated terrorist Lawrence Bishnoi and 19 others, over allegations of running a vast trans-border empire involved in contract killings and extortion.

● Two 2021 cases against Sukesh Chandrashekhkar pertaining to allegations of a Rs 200-

har-e-Taiba chief Mohd Hafeez Saeed for alleged terror funding.

● A 2017 case against Lask-

crore extortion racket.

● A 2022 case against Oma Salam, the then chairman of the now banned Popular Front of India (PFI), of alleged “transnational conspiracy” to raise funds and of holding “radicalisation” training camps.

● A 2022 case against Canada-based Arshdeep Dalla, of alleged involvement with the Khalistan Tiger Force (KTF).

● A 2023 case related to ethnic violence in Manipur.

● A 2024 case involving human trafficking and cyber-slavery allegations. **WITH INPUTS BY VINEET BHALLA**



India a trusted partner, only 1% of trade deal talks left: Gor

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, May 29

SERGIO GOR, US Ambassador to India, said Friday that Washington expects that a bilateral trade deal with India will be signed in “next few weeks and months”. He indicated that only “1 percent” of the deal was left to be concluded and Indian and US negotiators were working on it.

Describing Secretary of State Marco Rubio’s recent four-day visit to India as “substantive”, Gor, speaking at the US-India TRUST Initiative event at IIT Delhi, said, “Just last week, India had sent a team to Washington DC to finalise the last 1 per cent of that trade deal. Next week we will welcome a US delegation here to continue those talks.”

“We fully expect that the trade deal will be signed over the next few weeks and months,” he said.

Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson for the Ministry of External Affairs, made similar remarks Friday. “We had a trade team which visited the US in April... and now we are expecting a



US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor addresses the US-India Trust Initiative event at IIT Delhi, Friday. PTI

team from US to visit India next week, where negotiations will be taken forward. So far, we have had a positive and constructive engagement,” Jaiswal said.

Earlier, the Commerce Ministry had said that a high-level US trade delegation was scheduled to visit from June 1-4 to iron out the remaining clauses of the proposed bilateral agreement.

Gor said there was limitless potential to take forward the US-India relationship. “The importance of India is now... not only economically but strategically to

the world.”

The envoy said the TRUST (Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technologies) initiative, launched during PM Narendra Modi’s visit to Washington earlier this year, was helping deepen cooperation in critical and emerging technologies such as AI, semiconductors, quantum computing, biotechnology, energy and space.

Underlining the exponential trajectory of the economic relationship, Gor noted that bilateral trade in goods and services had

skyrocketed from just USD 20 billion to over USD 220 billion in the past two decades. He said the US is focusing on partnerships with countries it considers trusted collaborators in emerging technologies, noting that “India’s one of those partners”.

He also highlighted India’s inclusion in the Pax Silica initiative, a technology and supply-chain network led by the US.

“The reason India was in the first top 10 countries around the world to join this is that we trust this place. We trust the people here, we trust the technology, we trust your government,” the Ambassador said. He said India is joining “a network of trusted ecosystems and resilient supply chains” covering technologies such as AI, semiconductors and quantum computing.

On artificial intelligence (AI), he said major American technology companies are increasing investments in India. He also flagged cooperation in space, citing the recent launch of the NASA-ISRO NISAR mission and India’s participation in the Axiom-4 mission.

ON AGENDA: DISCUSSIONS WITH PM ON STRENGTHENING TIES, INDUSTRY INTERACTIONS IN MUMBAI

Myanmar President’s India visit starts today

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, May 29

MYANMAR PRESIDENT U Min Aung Hlaing is set to begin his India visit, his first to the country since he took over last month, on Saturday.

He will hold bilateral talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday, after visiting Bodh Gaya in Bihar over the weekend. He will also travel to Mumbai on Tuesday.

Hlaing, the former chief of the military junta government, was elected President on April 3 through a parliamentary vote – five years after the elected government was ousted in a coup.

Ministry of External Affairs’ official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Friday that



U Min Aung Hlaing was elected Myanmar President on April 3 through a parliamentary vote

Hlaing, who was scheduled to arrive in India to participate in the International Big Cat Alliance Summit on June 1, which has since been deferred, will now pay an official visit to the country from May 30 to June 3.

He will be accompanied by a high-level delegation compris-

E. EXPLAINED

Why Myanmar matters

INDIA SHARES a long land border with Myanmar as well as a maritime boundary in the Bay of Bengal. Four northeastern states — Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur and Mizoram — share a boundary with the southeast Asian nation. This makes it important for India to engage with Myanmar’s leadership for security and defence domains, despite the human rights concerns and other challenges there.

ing several Cabinet ministers, senior officials and business leaders. “During his visit to New Delhi, President U Min Aung Hlaing will hold discussions with Prime Minister Modi on June 1 on further strengthening the historical and civilisational ties between the two countries. He will also participate in a business forum,” the MEA spokesperson said.

“Regarding border security, connectivity, and other issues, all matters that form part of the gamut of relations between Myanmar and India will come up for discussion. Our idea is to take our friendly, civilizational ties forward,” Jaiswal said.

During his Mumbai visit, Hlaing will hold business and industry interactions besides

site visits.

On strategic objectives behind the visit, the MEA spokesperson said that “Myanmar lies at the confluence of India’s Neighborhood First, Act East and MAHASAGAR policies. The official visit of President U Min Aung Hlaing to India is expected to further strengthen and deepen the multi-faceted relations between the two countries”.

Officials said India shares a long land border of over 1,643 kms with Myanmar as well as a maritime boundary. This makes it important to engage with Myanmar’s leadership for security and defence domains, officials said, despite the challenges and the human rights concerns there.

The Editorial Page

SATURDAY, MAY 30, 2026

India, US: From estranged to engaged to restrained democracies

On fertiliser, Centre and states must align policy

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi wants Indian farmers to cut consumption of chemical fertilisers by 25-50 per cent, in order to conserve precious foreign exchange as well as protect the long-term fertility of Indian soils. However, the governments in Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra are doing the opposite. All three — many more may follow — have decreed that manufacturers and suppliers of subsidised fertilisers such as urea and di-ammonium phosphate (DAP) cannot sell nutrient products where no government subsidy or price controls are in place. In other words, fertiliser companies can sell only those products whose usage is being discouraged by the Modi government. They have been banned from selling any bio, nano, water-soluble and liquid speciality fertilisers or micronutrients and bio-stimulants.

The ban orders are not only an example of the Centre and states working at cross purposes, but also of ease of doing business going into reverse. Most of the non-subsidised nutrient products being marketed by the likes of Iffco, Coromandel International and Yara Fertilisers are applied in low doses for high-value crops such as grapes, apple and pomegranate. Moreover, they are notified under the Centre's Fertiliser Control Order after field trials for bio-efficacy and toxicology conducted by the Indian Council of Agricultural Research. What incentive would companies have now to innovate and introduce such products that can deliver nutrients more efficiently either straight into the plant's root zone via drip irrigation or onto leaves by foliar application? If the Modi government is serious about weaning away farmers from urea and DAP — whose applied nutrients are more prone to volatilisation, leaching or locking in soils than being available for uptake by crops — it should crack down on states that are sending contrary signals to the industry and farmers alike.

India has enough land, water and sunshine for growing crops. But that's not the case with fertilisers, where it is overwhelmingly import-dependent. In 2025-26, the country's imports of fertiliser inputs and products were valued at about \$27.2 billion. The unresolved West Asia conflict and closure of the Strait of Hormuz could result in that bill even surpassing the 2022-23 high of \$33.4 billion post Russia's invasion of Ukraine. The current crisis is both a moment of reckoning and an opportunity to transform the existing product-specific fertiliser subsidy regime into an expanded PM-Kisan 2.0 direct income support programme. When fertiliser prices are market-determined, farmers will start using the right nutrients in the required quantities for their crops. And they will be enabled even more when guaranteed a minimum income per acre per crop.

Meanwhile, Israel goes on with its wrecking ball

IN A clear violation of the October 2025 Donald Trump-brokered ceasefire between Israel and Hamas, Benjamin Netanyahu said on Thursday that he had ordered the military to take control of 70 per cent of Gaza, where the population is crammed into the little territory that remains habitable. That Israel was not abiding by the ceasefire had long been evident from its continued strikes on Gaza even as West Asia was engulfed by the Iran war. Yet it is difficult not to wonder if Netanyahu's decision to escalate further, at this particular moment, serves his political objectives ahead of the country's first elections since Hamas's horrific October 7, 2023 terror attack.

The past few weeks have not gone Netanyahu's way. Tel Aviv has largely been sidelined in the talks between Tehran and Washington aimed at ending a war that the US and Israel jointly initiated. Trump and Netanyahu's tense phone call a few days ago underscored their differing approaches to Iran, an inevitable divergence given the war's growing unpopularity in the US and the mounting political costs for the Trump administration. Netanyahu's apparent pursuit of eternal war follows a familiar script: Prolong conflict for political self-preservation and to defer domestic accountability for the October 7 security failure. In more than two years, Israel has failed to achieve its stated objective of destroying Hamas, even as it has killed at least 75,000 civilians and reduced Gaza to dust and ashes.

When Trump emerged as the unlikely peacemaker in Gaza, there was a sense of optimism about resolving the Israel-Palestine conflict. Announcing his 20-point plan and the "Board of Peace", the US president had declared: "The people of Gaza have suffered long enough. The time is NOW." Since then, however, Israel's repeated violations of the ceasefire have effectively shredded the plan, while the peace board is yet to receive any of the billions of dollars pledged by donors. Peace in Gaza requires Israeli restraint and an institutional credibility capable of assuaging Palestinian fears. Netanyahu's latest order does precisely the opposite. And the one man who claims he can make the Israeli PM do "whatever I want him to do" has turned a blind eye.

IT WAS an American diplomat, Dennis Kux, who famously termed the United States and India "estranged democracies" during the Cold War era. The historic India-US civil nuclear energy agreement, authored by President George Bush and Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, was seen as converting them into "engaged democracies". That honeymoon is not viewed any longer as having lasted more than a decade. President Donald Trump, it is widely believed, has downgraded a "strategic partnership", what President Barack Obama called the "defining partnership of the 21st century", to a purely transactional relationship.

The recent visit of US Secretary of State Marco Rubio is being interpreted as an attempt to reduce the transactionalism and return to a more "strategic" relationship based on "geopolitical" convergence. However, it bears mentioning that even this "convergence" of interests is defined by transactionalism.

The fact is that the so-called India-US strategic partnership was always based on a transactional foundation. Several quid pro quos defined the terms of negotiations of the nuclear deal. India's willingness to sign on to "A New Framework for the US-India Defence Relationship" in June 2005 was the key that opened the door to negotiations on a nuclear deal.

The framework established a Defence Policy Group that would, as the agreement stated, "expand two-way defence trade between our countries. The United States and India will work to conclude defence transactions, not solely as ends in and of themselves, but as a means to strengthen our countries' security, reinforce our strategic partnership, achieve greater interaction between our armed forces, and build greater understand-

ing between our defence establishments."

The intention was to secure an opening-up of the Indian defence market to US business, reducing India's dependence on Russia. Going beyond this commitment, India was required to reduce dependence on oil imports from Iran and Venezuela. The US establishment drove a hard bargain that finally required a presidential veto to get the agreement signed. Credit must go to Bush for taking a long-term view of India's economic rise and restricting the element of transactionalism in the partnership.

Bush viewed India's rise as a global public good and in itself serving US strategic interests. Trump upended that perspective when he made the relationship mainly transactional. Whatever the rhetoric that now fills up new documents signed by the two governments, the fact is that the US establishment is no longer willing to give India a free pass.

This in itself is understandable. What has come to hurt the relationship is the fact that the US has taken steps unmindful of the consequences for India. The unilateral actions on the trade front, the support to Israel in destabilising the Gulf, pushing oil and gas prices up and reducing access to these, and the new relationship with Pakistan all have adverse geopolitical and geo-economic consequences for India.

The weaponisation of trade, finance and energy flows by the US, with its allies playing second fiddle, has deeply hurt Indian economic interests, impacting India's economic rise, and as a consequence, its national security and global standing. Barely two years ago, the New Delhi establishment was celebrating India's emergence as the world's third-largest econ-



SANJAYA BARU

Whatever the rhetoric that now fills up new documents signed by the two governments, the fact is that the US establishment is no longer willing to give India a free pass

omy. As a consequence of both domestic and global developments, India has slipped back to the sixth rank.

A naïve hope is being expressed by some that the extensive people-to-people relationship between the two democracies will somehow help secure the relationship. It is time for a reality check with respect to the role of the so-called diaspora in the bilateral relationship. It is true that in the 1990s and early 2000s the Indian American community did play a facilitating role in strengthening the bilateral partnership. However, evidence today suggests that two aspects of the diaspora have come to limit its positive role.

As I have elaborated in my recent book, *Secession of the Successful: The Flight Out of New India*, the Indian American community, especially second- and third-generation immigrants, have become an integral part of MAGA — making America great again. Their role in "making India great" is increasingly limited as elite emigration has come to define exit from India to the West.

While Indian political leadership and media celebrate the achievements of high-profile Indian Americans, it should be remembered that they are now increasingly American and less Indian. They have become an important part of the engine of American economic resurgence. As US Congressman Jim Himes put it candidly, Indian Americans are "a secret weapon for (American) economic growth".

Second, people-to-people connect means little when larger geopolitical and national interests are in play and define Trump's "America First" policy. Despite all the visible nationalism of overseas Indians, on display every time Prime Minister Narendra Modi

travels abroad, non-resident Indians (NRIs) have become "non-returning Indians". Moreover, the communalisation of the Indian diaspora and growing Western concerns about the direction of Indian domestic politics, with implications for minority rights, have also come to limit the so-called "soft power" of the diaspora.

It is time for Indian policymakers and analysts to come to terms with the reality of a fundamental shift away from the "strategic partnership", which defined the move from "estrangement" to "engagement" at the turn of the century and in the first decade-and-a-half, to the more "what's in it for me" transactionalism that has come to define a restrained relationship.

It is just as well that External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar defined India's approach to the new realities of the world as "multi-alignment". The full meaning and implications of multi-alignment appear not to have sunk into the minds of analysts and media. If actions taken by both the US and China are hurting Indian economic interests, then Indian policy must be based on a recognition of this fact. Neither power is going to help build India as a third pole of the global economy.

Addressing the Constituent Assembly in December 1949, Jawaharlal Nehru famously said that India's foreign policy would have to be defined by her economic policy and interests. The Modi government's policy of *atmanirbharta* is defined by the same approach. India's external relationships must once again give precedence to our national economic interests and not be defined only by concerns about defence and security.

The writer is former editor, The Financial Express and was media advisor to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh

The Ideas Page

SATURDAY, MAY 30, 2026

A democracy must worry about fake voters, but much more about excluded citizens



FAIZAN MUSTAFA
AND MADHAV ANAND

IN *INDIRA Nehru Gandhi v Raj Narain* (1975), Chief Justice A N Ray made a strange distinction. Democracy, he held, may be part of the basic structure, but free and fair elections could not themselves be elevated to that status. But post-Emergency, in *Mohinder Singh Gill* (1978), the Court held that without periodic free and fair elections, democracy ends. In the *Gujarat Assembly Election Reference* (2002), it went further: Democracy and free and fair elections, the Court said, are “inseparable twins”. Free and fair elections fundamentally depend on the independence and absolute neutrality of the Election Commission of India (ECI) as an umpire, and therefore the onus is on ECI to win over the trust of independent observers and the Opposition. Here, what matters is public perception, not law or court judgments.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalaya Bagchi in their historic 124-page judgment has upheld the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of Bihar. No one can question the judgment’s positivistic and legalistic interpretation of the black-letter laws. But in terms of consequences, which Justice Ray denied formally in 1975, the present judgment risks diluting in practice if ECI is not a neutral umpire. The problem with the SIR judgment is not that it values electoral integrity too highly but that the court did not examine the all-important issue of whether we have got such rolls after SIR. There are reports pointing to inconsistencies, and significant inaccuracies even in the revised rolls.

Justice Surya Kant correctly held that no constitutional democracy can function with duplicate, fictitious or fraudulent entries. But the judgment did not raise the equally important possibility of genuine citizens being pushed out of the democratic process in the name of so-called “purification”. Did the petitioners not bring to the Court some living persons who had been shown as dead? But the judgment simply stated that no rolls can be perfect

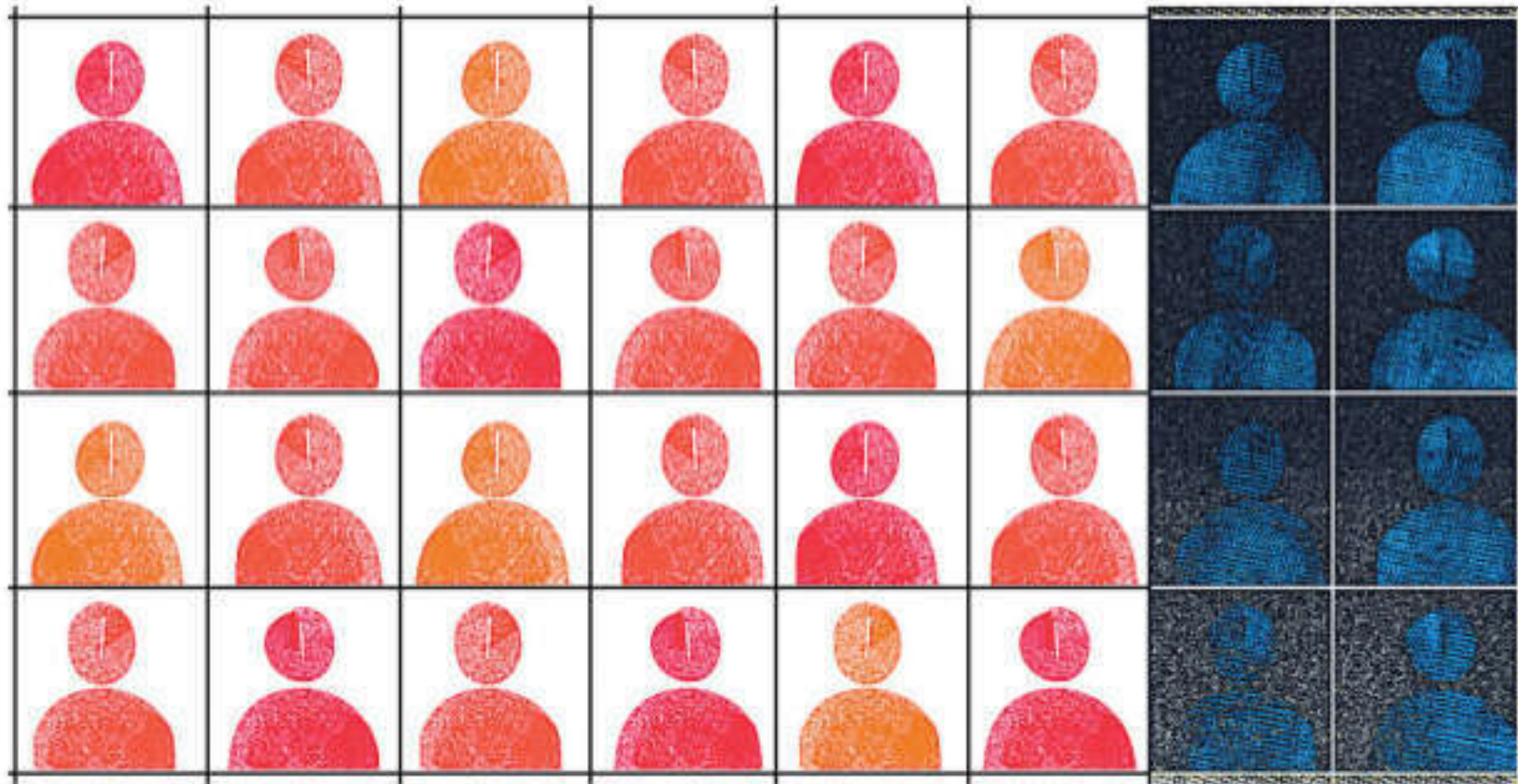


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

and that there was sufficient transparency in exclusion and opportunities of appeal.

Without asking the ECI to show concrete reasons, the Court accepted its justification for the statewide exercise. Section 21(3) of the Representation of the People Act contemplates special revision in “any constituency or part thereof” and Justice Surya Kant, applying the well-known rules of statutory interpretation, correctly held that “any” here would mean “all”.

Justice Surya Kant’s interpretation of Article 324 and 327, too, is absolutely correct as the ECI neither becomes powerless the moment Parliament enacts a law nor becomes so powerful as to go against the statute. The CJI rightly held that Parliament itself through Section 21(3) has preferred to give the ECI extremely wide powers as to SIRs through non-obstante clauses by using the words “in such manner” and “as it [the ECI] may think fit”.

The judgment upheld documentary compliance as though the burden is socially neutral. Marginalised citizens lacking documents and minorities facing heightened bureaucratic suspicion do not stand on equal footing with more privileged groups. The ECI’s huge victory in the judgment was the Court upholding its list of 11 documents, but then the petitioners had argued that nearly 37 per cent of adults in Bihar lacked even one of the prescribed documents. For marginalised commu-

nities, this is even more concerning. The judgment also did not seriously consider the ground realities of massive confusion, administrative inconsistency, rushed timelines, and the enormous discretion vested in low-level local officials. Evidence of BLOs filling forms themselves, missing acknowledgments, and lakhs of forms being submitted without documents find no mention in the judgment because issues were framed purely in legalistic terms and not in terms of the impact when such powers are exercised.

Ideally, the scale of exclusion itself should have invited deeper constitutional scrutiny. The final roll reportedly stood at around 742 crore electors. This was substantially lower than official population projections that suggest Bihar would have approximately 8.22 crore eligible voters. Yet, the judgment concluded that the “post-exercise data” did not reveal disenfranchisement so “widespread or systemic” as to establish constitutional infirmity.

If the citizenship concerns were so marginal in practical outcome, why did they become so central to the architecture of the exercise itself? But this approach reduced constitutional scrutiny to aggregate numbers alone. The deeper issue was not simply how many voters were excluded, but who was really excluded. The SIR was justified as necessary to identify illegal immigrants and preserve electoral integrity. The ECI did

not provide any figures of non-citizens found in the electoral rolls but reports suggest those numbers to be negligible.

Districts recording some of the highest deletions reportedly overlapped heavily with Bihar’s poorest and most migration-affected regions. Muslims appeared disproportionately represented among excluded voters, especially in Seemanchal. According to one report, Muslims accounted for 32.1 per cent of exclusions across the state. Another report asserted that Muslim exclusion was not that disproportionate as it stood at 18.4 per cent. In contrast, the Hindu-majority districts recorded lower-than-average exclusions, reflecting a broader pattern where nine out of the 10 top Hindu-dominated districts were below the state average 6.05 per cent. How far there is truth in this alleged differential has not been examined by the Court. Women reportedly constituted nearly 60 per cent of exclusions.

Rule 21A in the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 requires the ERO to form an opinion regarding deletion and provide affected electors with an opportunity of hearing. The Court held that these safeguards were “preserved in substance”. Non-inclusion in the draft roll was treated merely as a temporary administrative stage rather than a substantive democratic injury.

Strictly in terms of law, the Court rightly distinguished between the formal “determination of citizenship,” which belongs to the Ministry of Home Affairs, and the Election Commission’s “administrative satisfaction regarding electoral eligibility”. Justice Surya Kant’s assurance that exclusion from the electoral roll does not formally divest citizenship offers only limited comfort as a few states have already started denying the benefits of welfare schemes to the excluded people. This reminds us of the havoc the Doubtful Voter category introduced by T N Seshan played in Assam. We now have millions of doubtful citizens.

The judgment is correct on questions of law as after all the SC is expected to decide cases in accordance with the law. It rarely invokes Article 142 to do “complete justice”. A constitutional democracy must certainly worry about fraudulent voters. But it must worry much more about the frightened, excluded, genuine and eligible citizens.

Mustafa is an expert on constitutional law and Anand is a legal scholar at NUIJ, Kolkata. Views are personal

Delimitation can bring more female-urban participation



SHAMIKA RAVI

AFTER THE 2026 Census, the Lok Sabha could expand from 543 to 816 seats. Most of the discussion has focused on how the new seats will be distributed across states. We add a complementary question, drawing on our analysis of all the 2,171 parliamentary constituency (PC) elections held in India since 2009: How will delimitation affect voter participation?

The 2024 general elections saw a turnout of 65.8 per cent — the second-highest of any Indian general election. However, urban turnout has been lagging. The fully built-up constituencies of Mumbai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and the NCR are touching turnout floors of 55 to 60 per cent, well below the national average. The rural-urban turnout gap, 4.4 percentage points in 2009, has gone up to 11.6 points in 2024.

Two changes have reshaped the geography of Indian voting. First, the long-observed pattern that big constituencies vote less than small ones — the “size penalty” — has vanished in the average data. In 2009, a 2-million-electors seat turned out 11 percentage points lower than a 1-million-electors one. By 2024, that gap is just 1.4 points.

Second, the divergence in Indian voting now runs along urban-rural lines, with a sharp gendered twist. The woman voter in a large rural constituency is the most engaged — turnout around 75 per cent at two-million-electors seats. The woman voter who lives in a large urban area is the least engaged — turnout falls to about 64 per cent. As constituencies grow toward 3 million electors — a frontier several Mumbai, Delhi, and Bengaluru seats are approaching — our model projects the rural-urban gap to widen to 22 percentage points for women and 16 for men.

The polling station is the third piece of the picture. Booth crowding has always been more severe in urban constituencies than in rural ones. The EC’s station expansion between 2019 and 2024 brought modest relief at the urban end. But between 2019 and 2024, the rationalisation slipped: Stations grew only 1.3 per cent against 7.2 per cent growth in electors, pushing up urban crowding. The resulting 1.28-percentage-point national turnout decline is fully accounted for by this renewed booth crowding. Booth crowding deters male voters strongly — it explains 19.5 per cent of the male size penalty in our data — but has little direct effect on women’s turnout (3.4 per cent). For them, mobilisation works through different channels: Campaign, household and time-of-day flexibility, and direct engagement with collectives.

Why does all this matter for delimitation? Because the size penalty looks like it has disappeared on average, but at high urban shares, it has not. Our model predicts that a 2-million-electors urban constituency turns out at about 65 per cent; at 1 million electors, it predicts a turnout of about 74 per cent. Splitting a 2-million-electors urban PC into two 1-million-electors PCs would raise the turnout by roughly 9 percentage points per half. This is the strongest empirical case for the 543-to-816 expansion.

What should the delimitation agenda then look like?

Put the new seats where they will actually raise turnout. The biggest gains are in the band of urbanisation that runs through the suburbs of Bengaluru, Mumbai, NCR, Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad and Chennai — constituencies that are 75 to 90 per cent urban, which have grown 46 per cent in electorate since 2009 (well above the 35 per cent national average) and where voters are turning out at the lowest rates. Targeted shrinkage of these large urban PCs is where the model predicts the largest turnout gains.

Build the polling station capacity alongside. A ratio of below 900 voters per booth — the level achieved after the 2018 rationalisation — has to be locked in.

Bring urban women into the participatory fold. The rural channels that have historically mobilised women — panchayat networks, anganwadis, self-help groups — do not extend to cities like Mumbai or Bengaluru. The right urban tools include women’s canteen schemes, urban self-help-group networks under the National Urban Livelihoods Mission, women-only polling booths, and mobilisation by women councillors elected under the 74th Constitutional Amendment’s reservation provisions for urban local bodies.

The next delimitation will also be the moment at which the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam (the Women’s Reservation Act) comes into force. Delimitation that creates smaller urban constituencies in the band where female turnout is currently the lowest, layered with women candidates on the ballot under the new reservation, and paired with the operational and engagement infrastructure that brings urban women to the polling station, can substantially close the urban turnout gap among women voters.

As India urbanises rapidly, the share of the electorate in metropolitan PCs will continue to rise. Whether that rising urban share translates into a falling national turnout, or into a renewed wave of female-urban participation, will be decided by what the Delimitation Commission chooses to do.

The writer is member, EAC-PM



RAM MADHAV

LAST SUNDAY, lakhs of tribal people from more than 500 different tribes travelled to the national capital. Their demand was for “de-listing”, a constitutional process by which tribals who have converted to Christianity or Islam would be denied ST status and the benefits that accrue from it, and an amendment to Article 342 to that effect. In the 1960s, a tribal Congress MP, Kartik Oraon, first raised the issue. His contention was that those who adopted Christianity or Islam automatically cease to be tribal because they no longer follow tribal customs and traditions. He demanded the exclusion of converted tribals from the ST list. He presented a memorandum of a JPC to PM Indira Gandhi, supported by 235 MPs, with a proposed amendment to Article 342. It read: “3. Notwithstanding anything contained in Paragraph 2, no person who has given up tribal faith or faiths and has embraced either Christianity or Islam shall be deemed to be a member of any Scheduled Tribes.”

Indira Gandhi didn’t pay much attention to the issue. In the past two decades, the Janjati Suraksha Manch has championed the cause. Oraon, who served as a minister in Indira Gandhi’s government, documented that barely 10 per cent of converted tribals were appropriating nearly 70 per cent of reservation

The CJI’s assurance that exclusion from the electoral roll does not formally divest citizenship offers limited comfort as a few states have started denying benefits to the excluded people

Who gets ST benefits, who shouldn’t? Debate continues

benefits. As the number of converted tribals has grown — around 20 per cent today — resentment among the non-converted, too, is growing. Their argument is that converts are enjoying the benefits of both ST reservations and minority welfare programmes. At the root of this problem is a constitutional anomaly. In 1950, at the time of the enactment of the Constitution, two separate orders for SCs and STs were promulgated. The Scheduled Castes order, in paragraph 3, categorically stated that “Notwithstanding anything contained in paragraph 2, no person who professes a religion different from Hinduism shall be deemed to be a member of a Scheduled Caste.” Unfortunately, the Constitution (Scheduled Tribes) Order, 1950 remained vague on the definition of a tribe. Resenting this, in 2010, tribal leaders submitted a memorandum signed by 27,67 lakh tribals from 26,253 villages to President Pratibha Patil, demanding the de-listing of converted tribals from the ST category.

Since there is constitutional clarity in the matter of the SCs, the courts have repeatedly said that the SC status cannot be extended to those not belonging to Hinduism, Sikhism and Buddhism. In matters relating to the ST converts, the vagueness in the constitutional provisions has led courts to take

In matters relating to the ST converts, the vagueness in the constitutional provisions has led to courts taking suggestive positions rather than issuing definitive orders

suggestive positions rather than issue definitive orders. In 2004, the Supreme Court held that although it cannot be concluded that “merely by change of religion (a) person ceases to be a member of a Scheduled Tribe”, it insisted that the matter needs to be examined case by case.

The core issue is whether, like SCs, STs can also have a clear definition. An advisory committee constituted in 1950 for the “revision of the lists of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes” vaguely stated that STs are characterised as such “because of the life led by them”. However, the Justice P B Lokur Committee, constituted in 1965-66, identified “primitive traits, distinctive culture, geographical isolation, shyness of contact with the community at large and backwardness” as the basis for identifying STs.

The current demand rests on the reports of Oraon’s JPC and the Lokur Committee, besides the Supreme Court’s observations. This is not against any religion or conversion. The converted SCs and STs have full access to the welfare programmes available under the minority category. This demand is primarily to ensure that the traditional tribal population is not denied its legitimate rights under the Constitution’s ST provisions.

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

ECONOMY

Why inflation rate is not the same as affordability

While policymakers focus on containing inflation rate, consumers care more about whether their incomes grow faster than price rise

TELECOM

The row over new Airtel priority tier for postpaid users

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, May 29

THIS MONTH, Bharti Airtel launched a new 'Priority Postpaid' service that will offer all its postpaid customers more consistent connectivity during periods of network congestion. This launch of this preferential service tier — using a technology called 5G “network slicing” — has triggered debate. Should premium users (read postpaid users) be allowed preferential access to network resources? Here's a look at how 5G network slicing works and whether it violates the net neutrality principle.

What is 5G network slicing?

Network slicing is one of the defining features of standalone 5G networks. Instead of operating as a single network, where all users compete for the same pool of resources, a telecom operator can divide the network into multiple virtual “slices”, each configured for a specific purpose. Think of it as creating lanes on a highway. While the road remains the same, certain lanes can be reserved for vehicles with particular requirements.

In telecom networks, one slice can be optimised for ultra-low latency applications, another for industrial automation, another for customers seeking a more reliable consumer broadband experience, and so on.

Globally, operators in markets such as the US, UK, Singapore and South Korea have already deployed network slicing for enterprise and mission-critical applications.

So how is this different from, say, paying for a broadband plan that offers greater speed?

5G network slicing is different. A premium broadband plan usually gives users access to a higher maximum speed under normal conditions, but all customers still use the same underlying network.

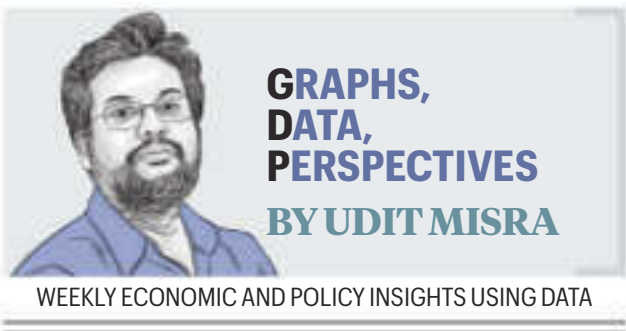
Network slicing changes how the network itself allocates resources. During periods of congestion, a user on a dedicated 5G slice can be given preferential access to capacity, while others may experience slower speeds or higher latency. In effect, broadband plans sell more bandwidth, whereas network slicing can provide a higher quality of service even when the network is under strain.

So, does network slicing violate net neutrality?

Net neutrality is the principle that all internet traffic should be treated equally, without discrimination based on content, platform, service or user category. Around a decade ago, India adopted some of the world's strongest net neutrality protections.

“As per my understanding of current Net Neutrality regulations, creating plans with higher speeds does not violate Net Neutrality, as long as you don't prioritise speeds for specific apps, services or sectors, or price access to different apps, services or sectors differently,” Nikhil Pahwa, founder of MediaNama, who played a key role in the successful campaign for net neutrality in 2015, said on social media platform X.

Critics argue that Airtel's plan creates a fast lane for customers willing to pay more, potentially undermining the principle of equal access. The Parliamentary Standing Committee on IT has begun examining whether the service breaches the non-discrimination principle embedded in India's telecom framework. Airtel, however, maintains that the service is fully compliant with net neutrality rules because it does not prioritise any specific application, website or content provider. Reliance Jio has also argued that network slicing can be compatible with net neutrality provided it remains application-agnostic and does not degrade service for other users.



GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES
BY UDIT MISRA

THE US and Israel's war on Iran and the resultant spike in prices of crude oil and other products critical to the smooth functioning of the global economy have made inflation the main worry for policymakers.

Between June 3 and 5, the Monetary Policy Committee of India's Reserve Bank of India (RBI) will deliberate on this matter. On its part, the Union government has as yet shielded average consumers in India from the full effect of the rise in international prices.

But while policymakers are focused on containing the inflation rate, average consumers in India focus more on affordability. The notion is best captured in the worries of several consumers, who bemoan that “once prices go up, they never come down”.

In other words, consumers are often more worried about the cumulative effect of past price increases on their household budgets and overall affordability than just the inflation rate in a particular month. This difference between the two ideas is also at the heart of the so-called “affordability crisis” in the US and the cost-of-living crisis in the UK. In both countries, affordability, more than just the inflation rate, is also leading voters to change their political choices.

What's the difference between inflation and affordability?

The inflation rate is the rate at which the general price level rises from one year to another.

Every country has chosen a representative basket of goods and services that its consumers use, and it tracks how the prices for this basket move. The year-on-year increase in this general price level is called the “headline” inflation rate, the one commonly referred to in policy debates.

As chart 1 shows, since the RBI adopted a policy regime to target a specific level of inflation in 2016, India's inflation rate has been within the RBI's comfort zone of 2% to 6% (red lines), even if it stayed above the

Inflation within comfort zone

Chart 1: India's retail inflation rate has largely remained within RBI's 2% to 6% comfort range



SOURCE: CMIE, INDIAN EXPRESS RESEARCH

target rate of 4% (green line). More importantly, over the past three years, the RBI has successfully brought down the inflation rate from almost 7% to around 2%.

The worry for policymakers now is that the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz is likely to push up the inflation rate for the current financial year (2026-27) closer to 5%.

The consumers, on the other hand, are more bothered about affordability, which, in turn, depends on two broad factors:

- The cumulative effect of repeated inflation spikes on the general price level
- The growth in their incomes relative to the rise in the general price level

In other words, consumers effectively care more whether they are better-off or worse-off in “real” terms — that is, after the effect of inflation is neutralised both from prices and incomes.

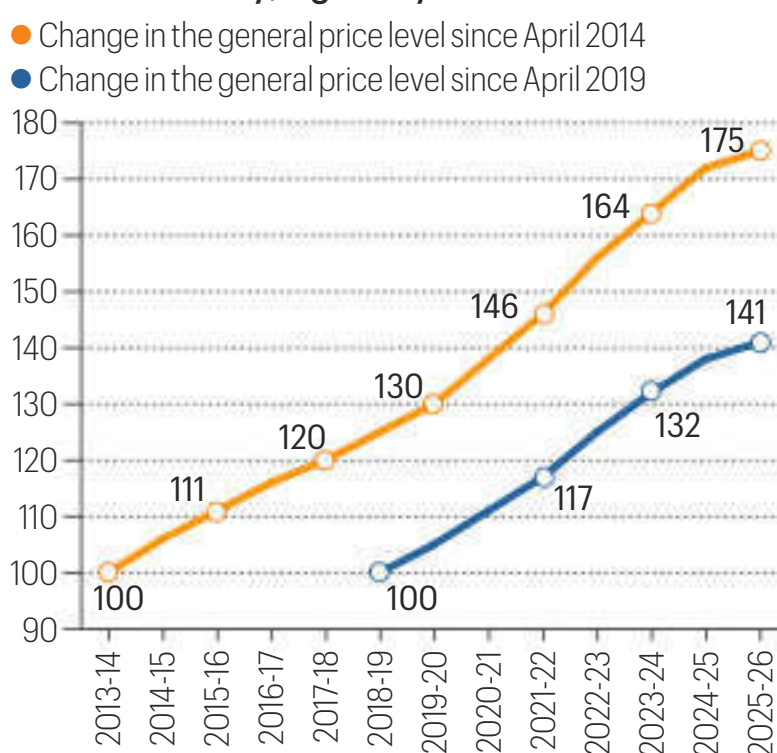
How to know where you stand in real terms

Did your income growth keep pace with the increase in the general price level? Chart 2 provides a simple test.

Let's assume the general price level as of March-end 2014 (the end date for finan-

Rise in general price level

Chart 2: Assuming price level was 100 in 2014, applying annual inflation rates shows it reached 175 in 2026. Similarly, it grew by 41% since March 2019.



cial year 2013-14) was 100, around the beginning of the first term of the current NDA government. If one then applies the annual inflation rates to this, one can arrive at the price level at the end of March 2026. As the data show, it is 175. In other words, a basket of goods and services that cost Rs 100 to consumers in March 2014, cost Rs 175 at the end of March 2026.

One way to assess whether one is better-off or worse-off is to compare incomes. If their income has gone up by 75%, then one is exactly where one was 12 years ago in “real” terms. If their income has grown by a lesser degree, then one is worse-off, and if the income has grown by a higher percentage, then one is better-off to that extent.

Similarly, the general price level has grown by 41% between March 2019 and March 2026. Calculations can accordingly be made for those who started working at the start of April 2019 (around the second NDA term), albeit the key number is 41% in this case.

What about the rest of India?

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) releases

Out of step

From the end of March 2018, growth in incomes of the salaried and the self-employed lagged behind the rise in the price level.

While daily wages of casual labour grew relatively faster, they earn the lowest in absolute terms.

TECHNOLOGY

How ACs catch fire, and the role temperature plays in it

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, May 29

RETIRED IAS officer and the first chairman of the Competition Commission of India (CCI), Dhanendra Kumar, 80, died in a fire after a suspected air conditioner (AC) blast at his Delhi home on Thursday.

The incident is the latest in a series of AC-related fire accidents reported in the National Capital Region this summer.

Just this week, a split AC reportedly exploded and triggered a fire on the 15th floor of a residential tower in Ghaziabad's Indirapuram. And, earlier this month, nine people were killed in a blaze at a residential complex in East Delhi's Shahdara, where initial reports also pointed to an AC blast as a possible trigger.

The incidents call attention to a disturbing pattern increasingly unfolding in Indian cities every summer. With higher average temperatures every year and rising AC sales nationwide, the likelihood of such incidents is increasing.

How do ACs catch fire?

Continuously running an AC, coupled with the high atmospheric temperatures during summer, can lead to overheating.

This overheating can degrade an AC's insulation, melt internal components,

and ignite combustible materials inside the unit.

Another major reason is short-circuiting, which occurs when the flow of electric current in a circuit takes an unintended path. This is not always dangerous, but when a large amount of current is flowing, it can, in turn, generate a great amount of heat. This can melt wires and lead to a fire.

The Delhi government's Department of Fire Services states: “About 60% fires are of electric origin on account of electric short circuit, overheating, overloading, use or non standard appliances.”

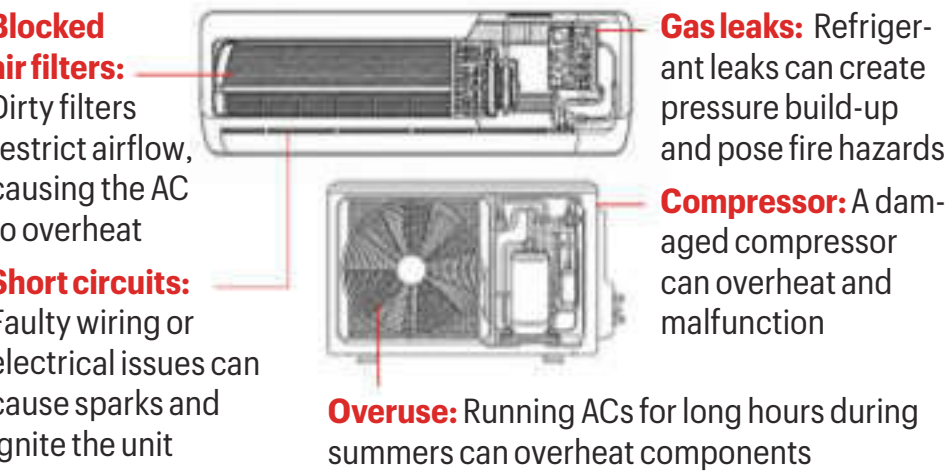
According to an official from the Delhi Power Department, house fires are commonly caused by short circuits in electricity meters, switchboards, or due to loose, poor-quality or faulty wiring.

“In AC units, fires usually occur due to gas leakage or overheating in the compressor, which is in the outdoor unit. However, in the Delhi incident, the suspected explosion occurred in the indoor unit of the AC, which is uncommon. Sometimes, if there is a spark caused by faulty wiring in a closed room along with a gas leak, it can ignite and lead to an explosion,” the official said.

Is an inverter AC safer?

In an AC, a compressor (the external box unit with a fan in split ACs) performs

Common causes of ACs overheating



SIMPLE SAFETY PRACTICES	
• Regular maintenance	• Clean dust on air filters, since it can hinder air flow and put pressure on the system
• Secure indoor/outdoor wiring connections, ensure that the circuit breaker and fuse are in good condition	• Set temperature between 24-26 degrees Celsius. Low temperature settings can stress the machine
• Install a stabiliser if electricity frequently fluctuates	

a crucial function. It is responsible for circulating a substance called refrigerant gas through the unit. Refrigerants absorb heat from indoor spaces and then release it outdoors. A non-inverter AC uses a

regular Periodic Labour Force Surveys (PLFS) that map employment, unemployment and income data. The PLFS divides the whole workforce into three categories of workers:

1. Salaried (regular wage earners)
2. Self-employed (e.g., small vendors)
3. Casual labour (e.g., those working on construction sites)

However, for reasons of data comparability, the only period for which one can get a representative picture is between 2017-18 and 2023-24. Still, it provides a broad sense of how India fared during this period in terms of affordability. From the end of March 2018, data shows that the growth in incomes of the salaried and the self-employed lagged behind the rise in the price level. In other words, in real terms, they became worse off during this period. The daily wages of casual labour, however, grew faster than the general price level.

It is noteworthy that casual labourers actually earn the lowest in absolute terms among the three categories. For instance, at a daily earning of Rs 453 in 2025-26, a casual labourer working all 30 days would have still earned only Rs 13,590 a month, while the self-employed earned Rs 14,861 per month and salaried workers earned Rs 22,699 per month.

Moreover, over this period, the share of self-employed — the category worst-off in terms of affordability — grew rapidly while the shares of the other two categories declined.

So, how can RBI help matters?

The RBI cannot directly do much about the income growth of different workers. That depends on a whole host of factors outside its scope.

On the inflation front, too, the RBI can't address the main reason for inflation: inadequate crude oil supply. Under the circumstances, all that the RBI can do is to constrain overall demand for goods and services among consumers by raising interest rates. Higher interest rates would slow down economic activity by making loans (be it for cars, homes or factories) costlier.

In other words, if RBI wants to arrest inflation, it will have to drag down India's economic growth; an action that mirrors what the government is doing by raising fuel prices and urging people to consume less.

fixed-speed compressor that runs at full speed until the room reaches the target temperature, then shuts off completely. When the temperature rises, it turns back on at full speed.

During extreme heat and prolonged use, this creates higher electrical and mechanical stress, which can overheat components such as the compressor, capacitor or wiring. If the unit is old, poorly maintained, or exposed to voltage fluctuations, it can lead to short circuits and fires — often referred to as “AC blasts”.

On the other hand, an inverter AC regulates the compressor speed gradually instead of constantly switching on and off. While this variability reduces stress in the system, it's not foolproof. Fires can still occur due to overheating of electronic circuit boards, faulty wiring, refrigerant leakage, poor installation, voltage fluctuations or lack of maintenance.

What are some signs of a safety risk?

According to Haier, some common signs of a potential blast include unusual noises from the unit, frequent cycling on and off, inconsistent cooling of the room, and burning smells/smoke. Professional services should be called in to fix these issues.

WITH INPUTS FROM ALOK SINGH AND RISHIKA SINGH

DIPLOMACY

Quad's struggle to find momentum, as members pursue disparate objectives



EXPERT EXPLAINS

MAJ GEN G G DWIVEDI (RETD)

WAR VETERAN, PROFESSOR OF STRATEGIC INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AT LAL BHADUR SHASTRI INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT

THE RECENT Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) held in New Delhi among the foreign ministers of Australia, India, Japan and the United States came as an assurance that the grouping remains relevant.

The Indo-Pacific has emerged as the world's strategic and geo-economic centre of gravity today. It hosts critical sea lanes, carrying over 50% of global trade and energy flow. China's rise, its coercive mari-

time behaviour, and technological dominance have created shared concerns among the Quad partners.

While the rationale behind the Quad has been compelling, it continues to grapple with a central question — is it a strategic force multiplier or merely a mechanism for consultative dialogue?

What is the Quad?

After the Indian Ocean tsunami of December 2004, India, Japan, Australia, and the US came together in an informal arrangement to coordinate disaster relief operations. In 2007, the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, commonly known as the Quad, kicked off. However, it never really picked up momentum, and while it was revived in 2017, the Quad has, at best, sputtered along since.

The major reasons for this are that the four constituents don't always have the same aims, and China strenuously opposes the grouping. Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi even compared the Quad to sea foam, saying it will simply dissipate over time.



(From left) Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Japanese Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio during the Quad meet.

Beijing argued that the Quad's purpose is mainly to target China. After the recent meeting on May 26, China's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning said at a presser, “We do not support the formation of exclusive cliques or bloc confrontation. No cooperation should undermine mutual trust and cooperation among regional countries.”

What do members want from it?

For Australia, Beijing's intimidating posturing means it has to expand strategic outreach and security partnerships, but it remains heavily dependent on China economically.

India needs to balance China in view of their shared border and the security calculus. It is also strongly opposed to China's design of carving out a unipolar Asia, but Delhi remains wary of compromising its strategic autonomy.

Tokyo views Quad as an essential security imperative, given the tensions in the South China Sea due to Beijing's apparently expansionist designs.

For the US, the Quad is perceived as the pillar of its Indo-Pacific strategy and the mechanism to balance out China without military confrontation. In fact, Washington perceives the Quad as a networked security architecture that substantiates American primacy in Asia. Under Donald Trump, however, the US seems to be leaning towards a bilateral deal with Beijing.

These different priorities explain why the Quad's progress has been incremental rather than decisive. The security cooperation remains constrained, lacking a NATO-like collective defence mechanism, and there is no binding treaty obligation.

What happened at this meeting?

The Quad Foreign Ministers meeting on May 26 attempted to break fresh ground. It focussed on maritime security, resilient supply chains, critical minerals and energy security amid geopolitical uncertainties.

Important initiatives were unveiled for enhanced maritime surveillance coordination, an energy security framework and co-

operation on critical minerals, to reduce dependence on China and the consequent vulnerabilities of supply chains.

The grouping also announced its first joint project — the development of port infrastructure in Fiji — signalling forward movement from dialogue to concrete deliverables.

What is the way ahead?

The Quad's future lies in strategic clarity among all members. To ensure organisational depth, the Quad needs to move towards permanent institutional architecture, alongside enhanced military operability, synergised technology partnerships and strengthened maritime capacity building in the Indo-Pacific.

The real test of Quad is not whether it becomes an Asian NATO, but whether the four democracies, with varying interests, can sustain strategic cooperation in the era of great power competition.

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INDIA'S GROWTH OUTLOOK REMAINS POSITIVE: RBI'S ANNUAL REPORT FOR FY26

RBI: War could pose headwinds to growth & inflation in short run

‘Elevated valuations in tech sectors may undergo reassessment, raising the risk of corrections in markets’

George Mathew
Mumbai, May 29

WITH THE monetary policy review a week away, the Reserve Bank of India on Friday said the West Asia conflict and risks such as higher energy prices, supply chain disruptions, financial market volatility, global trade uncertainty and weather disruptions could affect growth and inflation in the short term.

In a highly uncertain global environment, continuous assessment of the evolving developments is warranted to frame the appropriate policy response on an ongoing basis, the central bank said.

“Lingering geopolitical tensions and supply chain disruptions may pose near-term risks to corporate earnings and the performance of loan portfolios,” the RBI said in its Annual Report for 2025-26.

However, India’s growth outlook remains positive, it said. Considering various factors, and on the assumption that the adverse impact of the West Asia conflict would remain contained in the near-term, real GDP growth for 2026-27 is projected at 6.9% with risks tilted to the downside, the report said.

The RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee kept the main repo rate unchanged at 5.25% in the April review.

However, the rupee remains volatile at 95 against the dollar and capital outflows continue unabated amid the US-Iran conflict. The government’s decision to hike fuel prices is likely to put upward pressure on inflation.

While the ongoing geopolitical tensions are likely to exert pressure on the availability and prices of key inputs, particularly fertilisers, the government’s continued efforts in ensuring adequate availability of fertiliser and other key inputs through diversified sources and buffer management are expected to mitigate these potential concerns, the RBI said.

The central bank said geopolitical risk has re-emerged as the dominant drag on global growth in 2026. “The adverse impact of outbreak of the conflict in West Asia in end-February 2026 is reflected in the forecasts of global growth and inflation,” the RBI said.

With continued geopolitical tensions, inflation faces upside risks globally, the RBI said. “The surging energy prices and disruptions in key shipping routes could intensify supply-side pressures.” The RBI also said elevated valuations in technology sectors may undergo reassessment, raising the risk of corrections in equity markets.

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The RBI has projected FY27 real GDP growth to be at 6.9%. REUTERS

RBI plans ‘kill switch’: How it can stop scams

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, May 29

THE RESERVE BANK of India is exploring the possibility of introducing a ‘kill switch’ mechanism that would allow users at the receiving end of a potential digital scam to immediately stop all financial transactions from their accounts.

Besides, it has also proposed a ‘switch on’ and ‘switch off’ facility for all digital payment modes. It would help bolster consumer confidence and contribute towards con-

trolling frauds in digital payment transactions, the RBI Annual Report said.

The proposal for a ‘kill switch’ — being examined by the government and the RBI — envisages, among other possibilities, an emergency button integrated into payment applications of lenders that could instantly freeze all banking operations when a user suspects they are being targeted by fraudsters.

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Bank fraud nos down; amount up 46% in FY26

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, May 29

THE AMOUNT involved in fraud cases reported by the banking sector shot up by 46% to Rs 48,021 crore during FY2026 as against Rs 32,803 crore in the previous year.

However, the number of fraud cases dipped to 10,114 from 23,722 a year ago, the Reserve Bank of India’s Annual Report said.

Of this public sector banks accounted for Rs 35,709 crore in FY 26 as against Rs 23,617 crore last year and private sector Rs 11,399 crore (Rs 8,927 crore), the RBI said.

Data pertaining to FY26 includes fraud classification in 314 cases amounting to Rs 30,199 crore, pertaining to previous financial years, reported afresh during the current financial year after re-examination and ensuring compliance with the judgement of the Supreme Court, dated March 27, 2023, the RBI said.

Amount involved in advances of banks shot up to Rs 40,774 crore in 8,640 fraud cases as against Rs 30,367 crore (7,924 cases) in the previous financial year.

“Frauds reported in a year could have occurred several years prior to the year of reporting,” the central bank said.

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Govt dials fund managers for gig workers’ safety net

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, May 29

THE CENTRAL government is consulting fund managers to bring social security schemes for gig workers, a labour ministry official said on Friday, about a month after several parts of north India witnessed protests demanding a minimum wage while citing rapidly rising cost of living.

“A huge part of our workforce is now getting absorbed in the gig and platform economy, and the potential is immense. Today, around 1 crore workers are employed in this sector, and the potential is to reach around 2.5 crore workers by the end of the decade. The government is focusing more towards this sector,” Ashutosh AT Pednekar, Joint Secretary and Director General (Labour Welfare), said.

He said that the government is in the process of operationalising various social security schemes related to accident and maternity for platform workers.

“We are in the process of creating various schemes and engaging with several fund managers to ensure the schemes are operationalised,” Pednekar said.

He also said that the Code on Social Security rules under the new labour code has already been notified on May 8.

“We are in the process of operationalising the Code, based on the rules through various mechanisms like the National Social Security Board for gig and platform workers, which is being operationalised. The board will look at unorganised workers,” he said.

According to Eternal’s (Zomato and Blinkit’s parent company) Q3FY25 shareholder

• UNCERTAIN WAGES

ETERNAL’S Q3FY25 shareholder letter says that average monthly earnings for delivery workers of Zomato and Blinkit — who logged in at least eight hours a day and 26 days a month — were Rs 27,726 in 2024, excluding fuel costs (which is a big expense for workers)

HOWEVER, ETERNAL’S then-CEO Deepindir Goyal had said that in 2025, the average delivery worker on Zomato worked just 38 days in the year and 7 hours per working day. Though he said that



it reflects the gig-style nature of the job, workers say that those types of average earnings are only possible when they do 10-14-hour shifts

letter, average monthly earnings for delivery workers of Zomato and Blinkit who logged in at least eight hours a day and 26 days a month were Rs 27,726 in 2024, excluding fuel costs (which is a big expense for workers who drive hundreds of kilometres a day).

However, Eternal’s then-CEO Deepinder Goyal had said that in 2025, the average delivery worker on Zomato worked just 38 days in the year and 7 hours per working day.

Though he said that reflects the gig-style nature of the job, workers say that those types of average earnings are only possible when they do 10-14-hour shifts. Besides, much of the earnings are tied to incentives that companies offer workers for meeting certain targets on a given day.

In the case of platforms like Zomato and Swiggy, for instance, that means completing a set number of deliveries in a scheduled amount of time, without rejecting a single order.

One cancellation makes workers ineligible for any in-

centive, irrespective of the number of hours they put in. Platforms like Swiggy also deduct worker earnings for rejecting orders, this paper had earlier reported.

About the e-Shram portal, Pednekar said that it already has the database of aggregators and “we can understand, on a real-time basis, the benefits which the worker can or has availed”.

“Just like the UPI and Aadhaar changed the digital landscape in India, the e-Shram has the potential of changing the way the benefits are given to workers, along with the portability of benefits, which is a challenge worldwide, including India,” he said. Workers’ protests in Noida turned violent in April with clashes with police and torching of vehicles.

Since the start of this year, workers’ protests have been going on across industrial hubs, even before the energy crisis deepened after the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

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WHO chief arrives in Congo, says Ebola spread can be stopped

Associated Press
Kinshasa, May 19

THE HEAD of the World Health Organization has arrived in Congo's capital, Kinshasa, to support efforts against an outbreak of a rare type of Ebola virus, as medical personnel struggle with a lack of equipment, a distrustful population and armed groups in region.

The World Health Organization said Friday authorities have reported 906 suspected cases and 223 suspected deaths.

"To come here is to really show to the community that they're not alone," WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus told reporters at the airport late Thursday.

"Pushing orders from my comfortable office in Geneva is easy, but I'm asking my colleagues to work with the community and I am asking communities to protect themselves," he added. The outbreak "can be

stopped," he said, but is "very complex."

Challenges like the high number of people displaced by armed conflict in the region and food insecurity are complicating efforts to stop the spread of the virus, Tedros said.

Containment has been particularly difficult because the disease likely spread for weeks before it was first identified in mid-May. The International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies has said three of its volunteers in Ituri province died after they were believed to have contracted Ebola doing unrelated health work on March 27 — more than a month before the first suspected death cited by the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention.

Meanwhile, the outbreak continues to spread faster than the response, despite health facilities becoming more organized and the arrival of more equipment.

● Ebola Vaccines Under Development

Global health agencies are racing to find vaccines, treatments and tests for a rare Ebola strain in eastern Congo.

OUTBREAK

- The Bundibugyo strain has caused 906 suspected cases and 223 suspected deaths in Congo.
- There are no approved vaccines or treatments for this strain.

LEADING VACCINE

- The main candidate is an IAVI-developed single-dose shot, seen as the most promising option.
- It uses the same platform as Merck's approved Ebola vaccine.

SECOND VACCINE

- Oxford University and the

Serum Institute of India are also developing a vaccine candidate.

- The WHO says doses could be ready within months for testing.

SURVIVOR-DERIVED OPTIONS

- Researchers are also studying antibodies taken from Bundibugyo survivors.
- One candidate showed strong protection in animal studies.

ANTIVIRAL DRUGS

- Gilead's experimental drug obeldesivir is being considered after exposure.

REUTERS

Pooja breaks Sahana’s 14-year-old high jump NR

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, May 29

POOJA, 19, STEADIED herself before attempting the 1.93m jump at the Asian U20 Athletics Championships in Hong Kong on Friday. She visualised herself taking the strides and jumping and seconds later, executed all of it in a harmonic motion to break the 14-year-old national record.

As she fell on the track shedding tears, in the background, Sahana Kumari couldn’t hold herself back either. The high jumper-turned-coach was constantly encouraging Pooja and the tears came out the moment she saw her own record being erased.

“It is a special feeling. I had always said that Pooja is the kid who can break my national record and she has done it today. Honestly, I was not aware that it’s been 14 years since I set the record. I came to know when calls started coming. It’s a feeling I can’t express in words,” Sa-

hana told *The Indian Express* from Hong Kong. “I didn’t want to cry but couldn’t hold myself in joy. She came and hugged me and it was a good feeling.”

Pooja, one of India’s brightest young athletes for the past two years, had been on the verge of breaking the national record for quite some time. In January, she had jumped 1.90m at the Indian Athletics Series in New Delhi, but her three attempts at the national record were unsuccessful there.

“After a point, getting a new personal best is not easy. We have to go step by step. I believe the national record is near,” she had said then.

Super consistent

Pooja’s consistency has been remarkable and she is unbeaten at the national level in six competitions, while holding both the senior and junior Asian titles.

According to Sahana, an early start to her athletics career and body coordination is the



Pooja jumped 1.93m to win gold at Asian U20 Championships. AFI

reason behind her meteoric rise and consistency.

“She started at a young age. Her body is perfect for high jump with excellent coordination. It is very rare for a high jumper to have equal hand action and leg lift. These small things matter. With her pro-

gression, she has a good chance to go past the 2m mark,” explained Sahana.

While Sahana was emotional seeing her national record erased by someone she has been advising constantly, Pooja’s coach Biran Sergey had another reason to be happy.

“The competition record was held by my wife (Svetlana Radzivil) and it has been broken by my athlete,” Sergey told *The Indian Express*.

Training under Sergey

Pooja started training with Sergey, the husband and coach of the three-time Asian Games champion, this season. It has resulted in Pooja going beyond her personal best twice this year.

“We are working step by step on technique, physical condition and confidence. She is very talented and disciplined, and most importantly, she trusts the process. A big role was also played by her first coach, who gave her the love for sport, the desire to work hard and the right attitude towards training,” Sergey said.

He made a few technical adjustments that have been vindicated but feels that they need to stay calm and focus on the upcoming big tournaments.

“We made some technical

adjustments, but I don’t want to go into details. We are working on many small things together — approach, rhythm, take-off and confidence in competition. We also pay a lot of attention to the last three steps before take-off,” he said. “Right now, the main thing is to stay calm, continue working and progress step by step. This year, there is the World Championships, where it is important to gain experience, but the main target is the Asian Games. We want to be in our best shape for it.”

Pooja’s consistent performances at the international level has also drawn praise from former greats of the game. Blanka Vlasic, two-time World champion and double Olympic medallist, had words of high praise. “Her progression is brilliant and she is just 19. She just needs to continue doing what she is doing. Once she perfects her technique, sky’s the limit for a young athlete like her,” the Croat had told *The Indian Express* last month.

Carlsen beats Gukesh after year-long wait



Magnus Carlsen contemplates his next move. AMIT KAMATH

Amit Kamath
Oslo, May 29

ON HIS last day as a teenager — and then again on his first day as a 20-year-old — world champion D Gukesh was reminded that there is still some growing up for him to do. On Thursday, the world champion picked up a fight on the board against World no.1 Magnus Carlsen, and lost.

“Gukesh sometimes plays a bit too ambitiously. He wanted to prove a serious advantage today, which I’m not sure there was,” Carlsen said later. “Eventually, he played himself into some trouble. And I took over more and more.”

Even though Friday was a rest day at the tournament, Gukesh turned 20 in the company of fellow grandmasters, including world championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov and Carlsen. The players spent three hours on sailboats racing against each other at Oslofjord in the annual Norway Chess games, where at least twice, impromptu chorus of ‘happy birthday’ rang out for a grinning Gukesh.

But just before the players were to get on the boats, a video from the social media team from Norway Chess dropped where other participants at this year’s event wished him. Right at the top was Carlsen’s message for him, delivered with a cheeky grin: ‘Happy birthday, Gukesh. You’re not a teenager anymore. So time to grow up.’

Ever since the World No.1 from Norway smashed his fist on the table almost a year ago in reaction to losing at the same tournament to the Indian, the chess world had been eagerly awaiting another Carlsen-Gukesh battle. Thursday’s game — the first of two instalments between the two at Norway Chess this year — did not disappoint.

Seats at the Deichman Bjørvika started to fill up half an hour before the first moves would be made. Fans paying NOK 300 (just over Rs3,000) had filled out the first two rows of chairs in front of the players.

After Carlsen lost two classical games in the first three rounds of Norway Chess, some of his contemporaries had been wondering aloud if he still had what it takes. Even by his own track record of ‘rusty’ starts to

tournaments, two losses in the first three rounds was unprecedented. Gukesh’s form, meanwhile, has been scrutinised for the past 18 months since he became the youngest world champion in chess history. Almost every defeat is held up as proof that he is not a world champion with impeccable credentials like Carlsen.

In a game that saw an exchange variation of the queen’s gambit declined, Gukesh, playing with white pieces, played aggressively, catching the world no 1 off guard at the start.

“Did I miss knight to b5 (Gukesh’s ninth move)? Yes! Was it an unpleasant surprise? Yes,” Carlsen said in an early visit to the confessional booth.

After Carlsen was left with doubled pawns on the f file, Gukesh had a small edge, according to the eval bar. But the Norwegian soon found a way to bounce back. While Carlsen had struggled to keep up with the clock in the unique time control used at Norway Chess till then, on Thursday it was Gukesh who found himself fighting time trouble in the middle game, needing to make 12 moves in seven minutes.

By the 30th move, Carlsen was winning after Gukesh’s bishop to e4. By the 39th, the world champion had to sacrifice his queen in exchange for a rook. Three moves later, he resigned.

Then the duo sat on the board for a few minutes discussing the intricacies of the game in a way they had rarely done after past encounters.

“It was a huge relief (to win today). After missing a few chances (in previous games), you kind of get little doubts in your mind. What’s it going to take for me to get it done? Feels good to get that monkey off my back,” Carlsen told Take Take Take after the win.

At the 2025 Norway Chess tournament, after Carlsen’s first-round win over Gukesh, the Indian had posted a quote from The Wire on his X handle: ‘You come at the king, you best not miss.’

On Thursday, his X account stayed silent. There is another Carlsen-Gukesh game coming next week, after all.

THE WRITER IS IN OSLO ON THE INVITATION OF NORWAY CHESS